



AMSTERDAM NETHERLANDS

Rijsttafel Feasts in Amsterdam

Vast riches have flowed between Asia and Holland for hundreds of years, from the 17th-century heyday of the Dutch East India Company to 20th-century plantation wealth. As well as funding the canal-threaded elegance of cities like Amsterdam, this historic link has left a delicious edible legacy, *rijsttafel* – an assemblage of classic dishes inspired by traditional Indonesian feasts.



Holland is home to over 170 nationalities, but the most intriguing food influence is Indonesian. The Dutch dominated this vast Asian

archipelago – home to evocative locations like Java, Bali, and Sumatra – from the early 17th century, taking full political control of the “Dutch East Indies” from 1800 until its independence in 1945. Politics and palates were intimately linked, however, and Holland was forced to joust with rival nations for commercial control of spice treasures such as nutmeg and cloves.

Colonial leaders met – and ate – amid the ornate courtyards of opulent venues such as the long-gone Hotel des Indes in Batavia (now Jakarta). It was in places such as these that a new type of feast gained popularity in the early 20th century, bringing together favorite local dishes in a dazzling showcase of Indonesia’s exotic flavors. Christened *rijsttafel* (“rice table”), it took inspiration from traditional Indonesian feasts such as *tumpeng*, where a mound of rice was flanked by dishes forming a taste symphony of spicy, sweet, sour, and salty. Classics included in the Dutch

feast were *teri kacang* (tiny dried fish fried with peanuts), *telur pindang* (marbled boiled eggs), sweet dry-fried *tempeh* (a fermented soy product), and *sambal goreng ati* (liver in chili pepper sauce). The dishes were Indonesian but the combination was Dutch, and today’s *rijsttafel* – consisting of 12 to 30 little dishes – is found mainly in Amsterdam and The Hague. Restaurants offering this delicious feast range from small, unadorned backstreet hangouts to upmarket foodie shrines that still nod to the ambitions of the old Indonesian chefs, who were renowned for trying to outdo one another with the quality and inventiveness of their dishes.

Amsterdam’s Tropenmuseum is a fascinating place to visit for a colorful overview of Indonesia’s influence on Holland over the past 350 years. Nearby, the Eastern Docklands showcase the city’s contemporary style – old, run-down quays have been transformed with 21st-century modernism to provide a striking contrast to the cobbled lanes and historic facades of the more traditional old downtown. The old docks also offer another island called Java, though this one is home to modern design shops and cutting-edge architecture rather than exotic food and valuable spices.



Above Amsterdam is a wonderful place to walk or cycle around; its colorful streets hide a plenitude of laid-back cafés and multicultural restaurants

What Else to Eat

Cheese is Dutch gold. **Edam**, a low-fat delight, is named after a beautiful 12th-century town on the shores of the IJsselmeer inland sea. Another charming medieval town gave its name to Holland’s other famous cheese – **Gouda** – which is still sold in giant wheels on the cobbled main square; choose between sweeter *jong* (“young”) or more pungent *oud* (“old”). Salty **raw herring** is a unique Dutch classic. Try it on its own (dangle by the tail and slip it into your mouth) or stuffed with onions in a roll. The perfect way to wash down the herring is with **genever**, a Dutch predecessor to gin. Also good on its own, you can enjoy a lip-smacking blast of this Netherlands gem in one of Amsterdam’s cozy vintage genever bars, such as De Drie Fleschjes on Gravenstraat or Oloofspoort on Nieuwebrugsteeg.

Three Days in and around Amsterdam

Short distances and fast trains make it easy to discover how much more there is to Holland beyond Amsterdam’s atmospheric canal-laced beauty.

DAY ONE In Amsterdam, reflect on artistic genius at the **Van Gogh Museum** and the **Rijksmuseum**, which houses works by Rembrandt. You can then visit his former home, the **Rembrandt House Museum**, or that of another much-loved Amsterdam inhabitant, **Anne Frank**. Then dive into the galleries, boutiques, and bars of the charming **Jordaan** area, or its neighbor, the multicultural **De Pijp**.

DAY TWO Combine culture and coast in Holland’s capital, **The Hague**, where you can see Old Masters at the 17th-century **Mauritshuis**, discover Mondrian at the **Gemeentemuseum**, then sniff sea air amid the dunes at **Scheveningen** or hop on tram 1 for a 20-minute ride to lovely **Delft** for an afternoon on its historic tiles.

DAY THREE Visit **Utrecht** to climb **Domtoren**, Holland’s tallest and oldest church tower, and see **De Haar**, a restored medieval castle. The city also has Europe’s only **Aboriginal Art Museum** and is home to the iconic Rietveld–Schröder House, a modernist home designed by Gerhardt Rietveld and Truus Schröder in the 1920s.

ESSENTIALS

GETTING THERE

Amsterdam’s large international **airport**, Schipol, is 15 minutes by **train** from central Amsterdam. There are also **shuttle buses** from the airport to around 100 of the city’s hotels.

WHERE TO STAY

Citizen M (inexpensive) is an exciting modern hotel with great facilities at an affordable price. www.citizenmsterdamcity.com

The Convent Hotel (moderate) is a central, 4-star hotel carved from two medieval monasteries. www.accorhotels.com

Hotel Pulitzer (expensive) offers canalside luxury in a row of 17th- and 18th-century houses in the Old Quarter. www.pulitzeramsterdam.com

TOURIST INFORMATION
www.iamsterdam.com/en